Supervisor Training: Facilitator Guide

Building Trust and Engagement with Your Team | Version 1.0 | Zachary Hunter

Session at a glance

Item	Detail
Course	Supervisor Training: Building Trust and Engagement with Your Team (Module 1: Leading through change)
Format	10 minutes, in person, one facilitator; includes questions
Audience	Supervisors; the room may include employees who don't supervise
By the end, participants can	Identify what's missing in a change message; write a sentence that fills the gap; start a template for a change they have coming up
Materials	Slide deck (22 slides, with speaker notes); one two-sided job aid per participant

Part	Slides	Time	Minutes
1. Two plants	2	0:00-0:45	0:45
2. Today	3	0:45-1:00	0:15
3. Think back	4	1:00-1:15	0:15
4. Fair process	5-9	1:15-3:30	2:15
5. What it sounds like	10-13	3:30-4:00	0:30
6. Which one is missing?	14-17	4:00-6:30	2:30
7. Your turn	18	6:30-7:15	0:45
8. Keep it going	19-20	7:15-8:15	1:00
9. Questions	21 (22 is a backup)	8:15-10:00	1:45

If behind: drop Part 3 first, then hold the Part 6 writing time to 30 seconds. Questions absorb the rest.

Key messages (protect these if time runs short):

- The same decision can land very differently; the process makes the difference.
- Fair process has three principles: engagement, explanation and expectation clarity.
- Fair process isn't consensus; the supervisor still makes the call.

How to use this guide. Study it before the session; the deck's speaker notes are your live reminders. Each cue is color-coded: **SAY** is suggested wording, not a script; bold lines are said word for word. **DO** is what you or participants do. **NOTE** covers contingencies. **TRANSITION** bridges to the next part. For why the session is built this way, see the design document. Dark slides (1, 4 and 21) appear here with a light background to save ink; the deck itself is unchanged.

Before the session



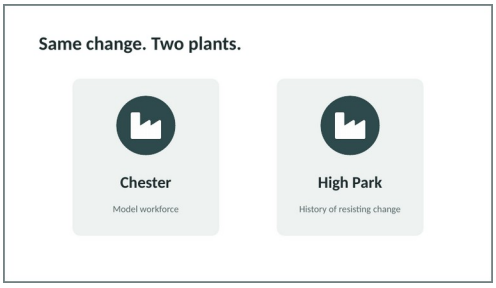
Prepare

- Rehearse to time at least twice.
- Load the deck and check presenter view.
- Place a job aid front side up at each seat (checklist showing).
- Greet participants as they arrive.

Materials

- Slide deck, plus the PDF on a USB drive as a backup
- Printed notes pages, in case presenter view isn't available
- One job aid per participant, plus a spare
- Pens for each participant
- A visible clock or timer

Part 1: Two plants (0:00-0:45)

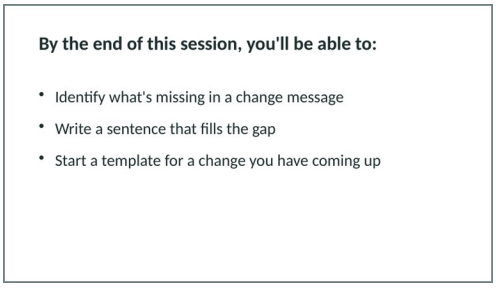


> **SAY** "Let's look at how one important change played out in two very different ways. Here we have two plants within the same company introducing a new manufacturing system. One plant, Chester, had a model workforce. Consultants showed up with no explanation, then management described the change in a 30-minute meeting and provided no reason or clear expectations. Rumors and fights broke out, and quality fell. Another plant, High Park, had a history of resisting change. Managers explained the business problem, invited employees to help design the new system, set the new performance measures, and gave clear expectations. The plant manager expected resistance, but it never came."

> **NOTE** Keep it under 45 seconds. The company is a pseudonym ("Elco") in the source. Employee input at High Park shaped how the change was carried out, not whether it happened; slide 6 calls back to this.

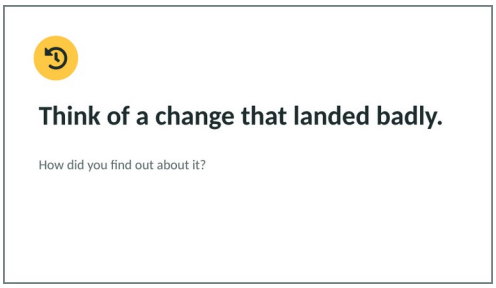
> **TRANSITION** "We're going to take a closer look at that difference."

Part 2: Today (0:45-1:00)



SAY "There are many ways to build trust and engagement. Today we're going to focus on one moment: when something is about to change on your team. By the end, you'll be able to identify what's missing in a change message, write a sentence that fills the gap, and start a template for a change you have coming up."

Part 3: Think back (1:00-1:15)



SAY "Before we go on, think of a change at work that landed badly. How did you find out about it? You don't need to share; just keep it in mind."

NOTE Private reflection; take no responses. Drop this part first if running behind.

TRANSITION "Researchers have a name for one thing that often goes missing."

Part 4: Fair process (1:15-3:30)



SAY (SLIDE 5) "With Chester and High Park, the company went through with the same decision. What changed the outcome was the process. Researchers at INSEAD found that **people trust and cooperate with decisions when the process feels fair, even if the outcome is not what they wanted.** They call it fair process. To be clear, fair process is not consensus. As a supervisor, you still make the call. It comes down to three principles."

NOTE Say "researchers at INSEAD" (pronounced "In-See-Ahd") rather than the authors' names, which are on the slide.



Slides 6-9 build the three principles one at a time.

SAY (SLIDE 6) "The first principle is engagement: asking for input from the people a decision affects, before it's final. If the decision came from above, you can still ask how to carry it out. At High Park, employees helped design the new system and set the new measures. **Engagement here means involving people in decisions. The engagement in the title of this course is bigger: how involved and enthusiastic people are about their work. Involving people builds trust and commitment.**"

NOTE Keep the engagement aside even when running behind; without it, the two meanings of "engagement" blur together.

SAY (SLIDE 7) "The second principle is explanation: sharing the why. This includes what happened with their input, especially when you didn't use it. People can trust your intentions even when their idea wasn't utilized, as long as they can understand the reasoning."

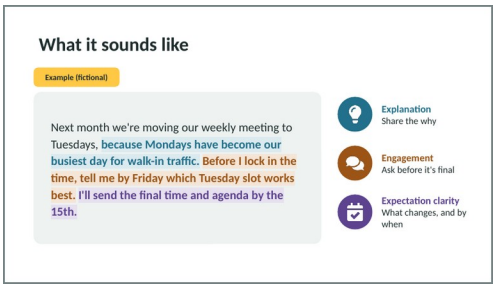
SAY (SLIDE 8) "The third principle is expectation clarity. Once a decision is made, say what changes and by when. With clear expectations, there's less uncertainty, and people can focus on the work."

NOTE If asked, the full source line: "When people clearly understand what is expected of them, political jockeying and favoritism are minimized, and they can focus on the job at hand."

SAY (SLIDE 9) "Managers who pay attention to how decisions get made often practice just one of these, usually engagement, and stop there. In our earlier example, **Chester had none while High Park got all three. Before your next decision or change, check all three.**"

TRANSITION "Let's practice spotting them."

Part 5: What it sounds like (3:30-4:00)

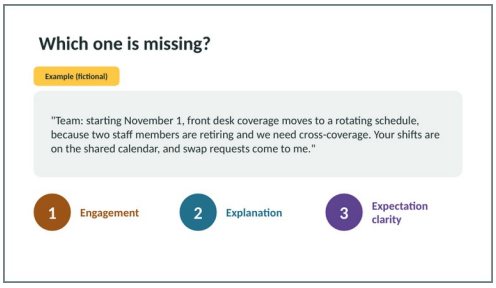


Slides 10-13 highlight one part of the model message at a time.

SAY (slide 10) "Take a look at this message." (slide 11) "Here's the explanation: the reason for the move." (slide 12) "Here's the engagement: they're asked which slot works before it's locked in." (slide 13) "And here's the expectation clarity: when the final time and agenda will come. Take a look at your job aid; the front lists the same three principles."

DO Point to the front of the job aid. Its back holds the Part 6 practice line and the Part 7 template, each labeled "During the session."

Part 6: Which one is missing? (4:00-6:30)

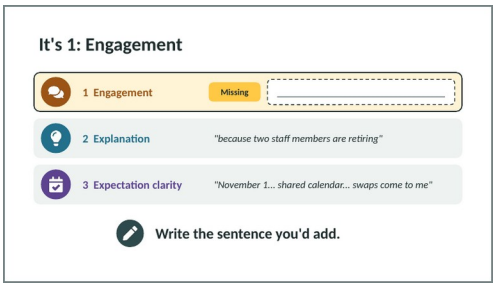


SAY "Here's another message from a supervisor. Read it over and think about which part of fair process is missing, but don't call it out yet."

DO About 15 seconds of silent reading.

SAY "On three, hold up the number of fingers that matches what's missing: one for engagement, two for explanation, three for expectation clarity. One, two, three."

NOTE The answer is 1, engagement. Count to three so no one copies the first hand up.



Slides 15-17 fill in the evidence one principle at a time.

SAY "The reasons are clear, that's the explanation, and the expectations are spelled out, but nobody was asked how this affects their work. Notice that 'swap requests come to me' sounds like input, but it comes after the decision; that's how exceptions work, which is expectation clarity. Now let's put it into practice. On the back of your job aid, there's a line for this. Take about 30 seconds to write one sentence that adds the missing piece."

SAY (ONLY IF SOMEONE HELD UP A WRONG NUMBER) For 2: "The why is actually there: 'because two staff members are retiring.'" For 3: "The what and when are there: November 1, the shared calendar, swaps come to me." Then: "What's missing is that nobody was asked."

NOTE If someone argues that swaps are engagement: "Swaps let you adjust within a decision that's already made. Engagement would be asking before it's final, so people could shape the rotation itself."

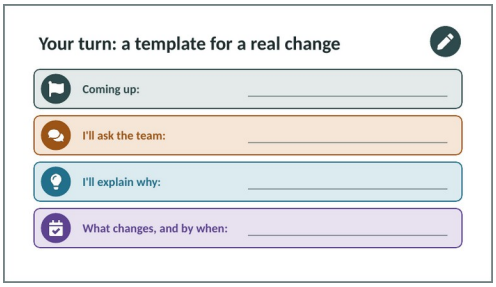
DO 30 seconds of writing (up to 60 if time allows). Glance at each sentence while they write; don't collect them.

SAY "Can I get a volunteer to share what they wrote?" Then specific feedback, for example: "That works because it asks before it's final." Then: **"How does that sentence build trust?"**

NOTE Model answer if no one volunteers or time is short: **"Before we lock this in, I'd like 10 minutes at Thursday's meeting to hear how the rotation affects your other work."** Virtual delivery: sentences go in the chat.

TRANSITION "Now do it for something real."

Part 7: Your turn (6:30-7:15)

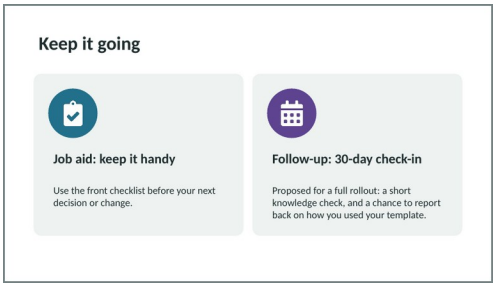


SAY "The back of your job aid has a template you can use when you have a real decision or change coming up on your team. It's the same one on the screen. Take about 20 seconds and fill in just the first line: what's coming up. Finish the rest before your next team meeting. And if you don't supervise anyone, this still applies. You don't need a title to lead this way. Pick a change you're part of, or one you're leading with peers, and think about what you'd want to ask and explain."

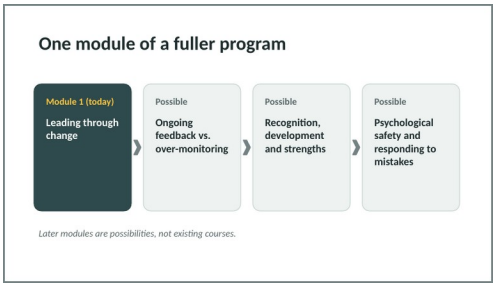
DO Individual writing. Do not collect; it is theirs to keep.

NOTE The non-supervisor line is the main takeaway for employees in the room.

Part 8: Keep it going (7:15-8:15)



SAY (SLIDE 19) "Keep the job aid handy; the front checklist is there for your next decision or change. In a full rollout, I would propose a short module in the College's LMS that follows up at 30 days, with a quick knowledge check and a chance to report back on how you used the template you started today."



SAY (SLIDE 20) "And that concludes Leading through change. This is one module I picture as part of a fuller supervisor training program, and I've included some possible later modules here. What questions do you have?"

NOTE Say "the College's LMS." The 30-day module is a proposal, and the later modules are possibilities, not existing courses.

Part 9: Questions (8:15-10:00)



SAY "What questions do you have?"

DO If there are no questions, ask what they wrote on the first line of their template. End on time, even mid-discussion.

NOTE Backup slide 22 lists the references if someone asks for sources.

Virtual or hybrid delivery

- Send the job aid as a fillable PDF before the session.
- The finger vote becomes a poll; open it on the count of three.
- Sentences go in the chat; ask everyone to post at once on a cue.
- Hybrid: everyone votes through the poll, including people in the room, so remote participants aren't an afterthought.
- Turn on captions.

After the session

- Before people leave, give out the reaction survey on paper or by QR code, using the standard training evaluation form where one exists.
- Enroll participants in the 30-day follow-up module (proposed).
- Note where timing ran over or under, for the next revision.

Anticipated questions

Answer from these points in your own words; don't read them out. Points marked (practical advice) are tips for applying the framework day to day.

1. What if the decision comes from above and I can't change it?

- Fair process still applies; what is open narrows to how the change is carried out.
- Ask about the how: timing, sequence, how exceptions are handled.
- Explain honestly: pass on the stated reason, say what you don't know, and don't fake agreement or blame leadership.
- Be clear on dates, what is measured, and how to raise an exception.
- Source: at High Park, management "shared with employees the company's dismal business forecast and the limited options available," and "Employees may not have liked what they heard, but they understood it" (Kim & Mauborgne). At High Park the company had already decided on the new system; employees shaped how it was carried out.

2. If I ask for input and can't use it, won't that make things worse?

- Ask only about what is genuinely open, and say up front what is already decided. (practical advice)

- Close the loop: say what you heard and why you went another way. That is the explanation principle at work.

3. Isn't this just consensus? Won't it slow decisions down?

- No. "Notice that fair process is not decision by consensus." The merit of the ideas, not consensus, drives the decision (Kim & Mauborgne).
- Asking can be one short item at a regular team meeting. (practical advice)

4. What if I can't share the reason because it's confidential?

- Say there is a reason you can't share yet, and whether you will be able to later. Don't invent one. (practical advice)
- Expectation clarity still applies in full.

5. What about urgent decisions with no time to ask first?

- Decide, then explain why there was no time to ask. (practical advice)
- Ask for input on how to carry it out and on what to do differently next time. (practical advice)

6. What if people still disagree after I explain?

- The aim is acceptance, not agreement. At High Park, "even when people didn't like the decisions, they felt they had been treated fairly" (Kim & Mauborgne).
- Listen, restate the reasoning, and hold steady on expectations.

7. I don't supervise anyone. How does this apply to me?

- You don't need a title to lead this way: use it for changes you're part of, or ones you lead with peers or on projects.
- When a change affects you, ask for the why and give input when asked. (practical advice)

8. How does this connect to performance planning?

- Policy 1.40 sets the minimum steps; fair process is one way to carry them out. The policy does not mention fair process; this link is drawn here.
- Planning: supervisors "seek suggestions" on duties, then "meet with the employee to review and discuss" the plan (p. 5). That is engagement and expectation clarity.
- Mid-cycle changes: "the employee must be informed" (p. 7). Asking first and explaining why goes beyond that minimum.
- Evaluation: supervisors "consider the employee's perspective or suggestions" (p. 5). Saying what you changed, or didn't, and why closes the loop.
- Scope: the policy covers non-probationary classified staff. Faculty follow a separate, dean-led process (the college's faculty evaluation calendar).
- If asked whether asking is required: the policy has you seek suggestions (p. 5), but feedback on the position description is optional and need not be implemented (p. 6).
- Spoken version: "The state policy already requires some of this: you discuss the plan with the employee, and you tell them when duties change. Fair process is how to do those well: ask before it's final, explain the why, and be clear about expectations. How the two tie together is something I'd work out with HR."

9. This research is from 1997. Is it still valid?

- It is a widely cited classic, not the newest work.
- Before a full rollout, check the newer research on fairness at work.

Sources

- Kim, W. C., & Mauborgne, R. (2003, January). Fair process: Managing in the knowledge economy. *Harvard Business Review* (reprint of the 1997 article). Basis for slides 2 and 5-9.
- Benefield, K. (2019). Templates for training facilitation. Penn State IT Learning & Development. Basis for the facilitator guide format.
- INSEAD. (n.d.). How to pronounce INSEAD? Basis for the pronunciation note in Part 4.
- Virginia Department of Human Resource Management. (2025, August 22). DHRM Policy 1.40, Performance Planning and Evaluation (revised 8/22/2025). Anticipated question 8; page numbers are the policy's printed pages.
- College working calendar 2024-2025 (name withheld). Anticipated question 8.